

TIMELINE

- **June 3, 1808** Born in west central Kentucky, near the Tennessee border.
- **1824–28** Trains at West Point, emerging 23rd out of a class of 33, and joins the infantry branch of service.
- **February 1835** Court-martialed on a charge of insubordination, Davis is acquitted but resigns from the U.S. Army in May.
- **June 1835** Marries Sarah Knox Taylor, daughter of future president Zachary Taylor. Moves to Vicksburg, Mississippi and becomes a planter.
- **September 1835** His young wife dies—probably of malaria. Davis himself is seriously ill.
- **1845** Marries second wife Varina Howell. He is the enslaver of more than 70 people by this time.
- **1846** Elected colonel of 1st Mississippi Volunteer regiment.
- **February 1847** Plays an important role in the American victory against Mexico at Buena Vista.
- **August 1847** The Mississippi state legislature appoints Davis to be a U.S. Senator.
- **1851** Defeated by Unionist support for the Compromise of 1850, Davis leaves the Senate and loses the gubernatorial race in Mississippi.
- **1853–57** Becomes Secretary of War in the administration of President Franklin Pierce.
- **1857** Returns to the Senate.
- **February 9, 1861** The Montgomery secession convention chooses Davis to be the first President of the Confederate States of America.
- **March 1862** Davis asks the Confederate Congress to pass a conscription act.
- **June 1862** After General Joseph E. Johnston is badly wounded at Seven Pines, Davis chooses Robert E. Lee to take command of what later becomes the Army of Northern Virginia.
- **July 1864** Replaces Johnston at the head of the Confederate Army of Tennessee with John Bell Hood—a disastrous appointment.
- **March 1865** Signs a bill authorizing the enlistment of slaves as soldiers.
- **1865–67** Imprisoned by the Federal authorities and indicted for treason.
- **1868** President Andrew Johnson issues an amnesty on Christmas Day that includes Jefferson Davis's pending charge of treason.